

Terms of Entry

New York City is driven by a continuous flow of people, information, and capital, where the speed of financial and media exchange is inseparable from the movement of bodies through its spaces. This pace is sustained by interconnected systems, as transportation networks, urban density, and vertical expansion intersect. While we do concede that the city is uniquely vibrant and stimulating, we find tremendous value in resisting its popular image, insisting on an understanding of New York through waiting, pause, and stillness.

The city is not incidental to the argument of the exhibition, because New York has a history of operating as a site where the environment has been shaped politically. The decisions that guide its infrastructure, as well as its cultural institutions and public spaces, create a geography where documented decision-making consequently traces a progression of spatial hierarchies. Moreover, New York has spent over 100 years building upward and tunneling underground, lengthening how long it takes to get from one end of the island to the other. Here, speed equates to progress, with enormous political and financial resources being invested into a promise that no one *productive* should have to wait longer than necessary. Time is money; therefore, waiting is a waste. Pausing, in this sense, is outside of the city's logic. To wait is to actively defy the priorities of a city epitomized by efficiency. *Terms of Entry* highlight the stakes that New York has made by directing so little attention to who has been left standing still.

New York's identity as a city of movement comes from a long record of attempts to manage, or justify, circulation across bodies and territories. [Early planning proposals](#) frame congestion as a problem to be solved through expansion and in doing so tie infrastructural

growth to the promise of uninterrupted flow even when that vision required the removal of entire neighborhoods. This logic extended beyond transportation, shaping how institutions structured entry, access, and duration. At the same time, scholars and critics have shown that this emphasis on efficiency has never been evenly applied, as critics like [Jane Jacobs](#) described the vitality of sidewalks as dependent on forms of presence that resist being reduced to circulation alone. More [recent work on public space](#) and control has extended this line of thinking, examining how design strategies shape who is able to remain, for how long, and under what terms. Together these perspectives locate waiting within a broader field of inquiry that poses it as a condition structured by the same forces that prioritize speed. Examining where and how waiting occurs offers us a way to trace how the city distributes time as a resource, making visible the priorities embedded in its spaces.

As a discipline, architecture is approached with a focus on circulation and program. Waiting spaces do not fit neatly into these two dominant frameworks as they are characterized by their temporal function and lack of movement, mediating bodies until the *official* program begins. As a result, waiting as a program is treated similarly to spandrels (byproducts), disguised by the illusion of neutrality. This is a crucial misclassification.

This exhibition asks how the action, and inaction, of “standing by” inspires feelings of (dis)comfort? Because it is a primary condition of a city, waiting spaces become a determinant of where and who gets assigned worth. The artifacts curated span performance art, photography, architectural drawings, art, and cinematography, offering a romance that exposes an untold history of New York that includes waiting and exclusion. We trace this story in stoops, lobbies, immigration centers, urban planning, designed exclusion/comfort, and prisons. This history is woven into the chairs housed in Guggenheim’s reception hall in 1946 to the tablecloth of

[“Shared Dining”](#) (2015), a piece produced by ten incarcerated women who actively experience the violence of waiting.

Terms of Entry invites viewers to understand New York not just through its movement, but by paying attention to the spaces where movement is withheld. Through its collection of artifacts and the design of the website’s delayed navigation, the exhibition sheds light on the overlooked experience and impact of waiting spaces. The (dis)comfort they create is not incidental, but rather deliberate. To wait in New York is never simply to pause, but instead an encounter with a system that evaluates one’s worth through time, comfort, and access.